Representations and legitimations in the texts about international students: critical discourse analysis using van Leeuwen's framework

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Background

- Increase of international students who come to study in the U.S.
- Increasing texts about international students, such as policy document, academic research, and newspaper
- Necessity of understanding discourses about international students embedded in the texts

Theoretical and Methodological Framework

This study was based on the framework *critical discourse analysis*. Language is not neutral, but continuously interact with society. Language is in use: 1) people use language for their own purposes; 2) language limits people's use of language and their thinking. So, we need to see language situated in social and political contexts.

In particular, van Leeuwen's framework about critical discourse analysis was used in this study. He assumes social practices are legitimized in everyday discourses by diverse strategies. This framework is helpful for this study to identify how international students are represented and how the representations are legitimized by diverse strategies in various texts.

Data Sources

This study addresses three types of data following as:

- Data 1. A news article about international students' feeling disconnected
- Data 2. A welcoming letter in the handbook for international students
- Data 3. An interview with a Korean international student

The reason of addressing diverse texts is to identify diverse representations and legitimations about international students. In particular, through comparing diverse representations, we can see what are said in some texts and unsaid. Moreover, we can comparatively see how the similar representations are legitimized in different ways among different texts.

The Purpose of this Study

This study aims to understand the representations about international students at the University of Minnesota-Twin Cities and the ways of representing, especially legitimations about the representations in the data.

Research Questions

- What are the representations about international students in the data about international students, including news article, the letter in the handbook for international students, and the interview with a Korean female international student?
- How are the representations legitimized? What are differences, similarities, and relationships among the representations in the data ?

Overview of Results

Representations in three types of data

Data 1 Welcoming letter	Data 2 News article	Data 3 Interview
Welcomed Collective	Equal Isolated Collective	Resistant Specific

Legitimations in three types of data

Data 1 Welcoming letter	Data 2 News article	Data 3 Interview
Moral evaluation Instrumental rationalization	Expert authorization Instrumental rationalization	Theoretical rationalization

Results: Representations

1. **Welcomed**: *warm*, *accepting*, *help*, and *welcome* **(data 1)**

"We think you will find this [the university] to be a warm and accepting community."

"ISSS staff are here to help you in accomplishing your academic and career goals."

2. **Isolated**: *isolate*, *confine*, *lose out*, and *(don't) reach out* **(data 2)**

"Students who confine themselves to their native cultures can lose out on important social experiences."

"They don't reach out."

"international students are more comfortable and confident when talking among peers from
their home countries, said Tram Vu...."

3. **Equal**: *both*, *both international and domestic students*, *they*, and *people* **(data 2)**

"It's a problem with both sides," Vu said, adding that she tries pairing with partners in classrooms outside her friend circle. "People need to be more open."

"We always invite both international and domestic students to come to our events, so we can kind of promote the beauty of the culture," Nguyen said.

Though they share classrooms, some students feel that national origins create distance at school.

4. **Resistant**: *express*, and *complain* **(data 3)**

"Very, the student expresses the opinion about the direction very actively"

"The student complained saying 'WHY not?' hhh."

5. **Specific**: "I," "a Chinese student," and nationality **(data 3)**

"I thought that there was no choice about the direction hhh."

"The student <the Chinese student> complained about the instructor's direction about the paper after finishing writing <her/his> paper."

"Koreans are more likely to be obedient, so they are viable to survive everywhere, hhh."

6. **Collective**: *many international students*, *international students*, *some international students*, *foreign-born students*, *some students*, *students*, and *they* **(data 1 and 2)**

"Each year hundreds of new students from more than 130 different countries begin or continue their academics at the University of Minnesota."

"The people of Minnesota place a high value on education and also realize the importance of having international students studying alongside students from Minnesota and the rest of the United States."

"We are delighted you have chosen Minnesota!"

Results: Legitimations

1. **Moral evaluation**: *centrally*, *warm*, and *accepting* **(data 1)**

"Our Twin Cities campus is **centrally** located in the **exciting** cities of Minneapolis and St. Paul."

"We think you will find this [the university] to be **a warm and accepting** community."

2. **Instrumental rationalization**: *help* **(data 1 and 2)**

"ISSS staff are here to **help** you in **accomplishing** your academic and career goals."

"Our office provides: Information to **help** you **adjust** to the University and to U.S. culture. Advising and counseling services to **help** you **maintain** your immigration status. Educational and social programs to **help** you **meet** U.S. and other international students."

"But to **help alleviate** the divide, student government leaders and international student groups at the University of Minnesota are **trying to figure out** what can be done **to make foreign-born students feel more comfortable** on campus."

"MISA hosts events like Feast of Nations and International Music Night that **promote multicultural interactions**, Vu said."

3. **Expert authorization**: the representatives *said,* … **(data 2)**

"During an outreach campaign to student groups last fall, international students told the Minnesota Student Association that they sometimes feel other students don't respect them, **said** Abeer Syedah, **MSA's student outreach and engagement director**."

"Bach Nguyen, **chief relations officer for the Vietnamese International Student Association**, **said** many international students feel their American peers don't value their input, which can lead them to isolate themselves within their cultural blocks."

"Students who confine themselves to their native cultures can lose out on important social experiences, **said** Roberth Garcia, a finance junior from Brazil and **president of the Latino International Student Association**."

4. **Theoretical rationalization**: *according to … cultural studies* **(data 3)**

"By the way, **according to** my learning from **cultural studies**, this reaction is really limitedly unique from Koreans"

Discussion and Conclusion

We can see diverse representations and limitations through three types of texts. These mismatches of representations among diverse texts about international students tell us that the representations in the discourses in diverse texts don't reflect international students as they are. The representations in the texts are the result of the authors' re-contextualization with consciously or unconsciously specific purposes and contexts. So, it is necessary for us, as the readers of those texts about international students to be careful for not just accepting the representations, but also thinking about complex relationships among texts and their social/political contexts.

These legitimations are natural to us: positively describing in a welcoming letter and quoting experts' opinion in a news article. Nevertheless, we can't settle for this discourse environment because, again, the discourse is not only language, but also social and political action.

These diversity and contradictions among discourses about international student are based on the limitation and possibility of language. Language can't represent all of our social practices. At the same time, from the lack of language, it can make us focus on specific representations. Therefore, first, we need to understand limitations of language and also utilize the strengths of language while imagining and circulating alternative legitimations about international students.

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